HOOK

Two agents just got a wallet

Not a feature request. Shipped product, same week.

- OpenAI gave ChatGPT agents a wallet to buy things
- Brave's search API now accepts agent payments via x402
- Both landed within hours of each other

WHAT'S HAPPENING

Payment execution is now a standard agent skill

Agents used to draft. Now some can pay.

- Agents could already browse, search, and summarize
- Now they can complete a transaction without a human click
- This moves agents from assistant to buyer

WHY IT'S MOVING FAST

Two separate companies, same direction, same week

That's not a coincidence, that's a signal.

- OpenAI: consumer-facing wallet inside ChatGPT
- Brave: infrastructure-level payment protocol (x402)
- One targets end users, one targets other agents/APIs

MECHANISM

How agent payments actually work

The pattern is simple once you strip the hype.

- Agent is given a funding source (wallet or limit)
- Agent decides when a purchase meets its instructions
- Transaction executes without a person approving each one
- Protocol (like x402) handles the machine-to-machine payment

THE REAL RISK

The danger isn't the AI, it's the missing checkpoint

A bad email draft gets caught. A bad purchase doesn't.

- Drafting a wrong email costs you a re-read
- Executing a wrong purchase costs you actual money
- Most teams have no defined approval layer for agent spend

WHERE APPROVAL SHOULD LIVE

Three checkpoints worth building before you give an agent a wallet

Pick the layer that matches the risk, not the hype.

- Spend caps: hard limits per transaction and per day
- Category rules: what the agent is allowed to buy at all
- Human sign-off: required above a set dollar threshold

LESSON

Autonomy and oversight aren't opposites

The useful systems have both, deliberately placed.

- Full autonomy sounds efficient until the first bad purchase
- Full approval defeats the point of having an agent
- The job is choosing where the checkpoint sits, not removing it

TAKEAWAY

Before you adopt agentic payments, answer this

One question before the tool, not after.

- Who gets notified the moment an agent spends money?
- If the answer is nobody, you're not ready for a wallet yet
- Build the guardrail first, give the agent money second

CTA

Thinking about giving an agent spending power?

Happy to compare notes on approval architecture.

- What would you need to see before trusting an agent to pay?
- Send me your use case and I'll tell you where I'd put the checkpoint

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